



**Valiant effort:** SRH can be proud of its performance this IPL, especially that of its domestic players who made their presence felt in the tournament.

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Head **(right)** redefined T20 batting, while T. Natarajan, SRH's top wicket-taker (19), added the slower bouncer to his already-potent yorker, making good use of the newly introduced two-bouncer rule. However, Washington Sundar, Abhishek's left-arm spin, and Shahbaz Ahmed were not fully utilised, largely due to the Impact Player provision.

In Qualifier 2 against Rajasthan Royals, Cummins, faced with a lack of a specialist spinner, was forced to turn to Abhishek and Shahbaz. They effectively wrecked the opposition's middle-order in the defence of a 176-run target.

The Royals also thrived with the re-emergence of Avesh Khan and Sandeep Sharma, who bagged 19 and 13 wickets, respectively, and were particularly impressive in the death overs, complementing

Trent Boult's wicket-taking form in the PowerPlay. As a result, it was the most economical unit in the last four overs of the innings.

The leap of faith the management took in backing Riyan Parag through thick and thin over the years also paid off, as the 22-year-old emerged

as the Royals' top run-scorer (573) after being promoted to the No. 4 spot. Meanwhile, Royal Challengers Bengaluru's (RCB) gamble with Yash Dayal not only bore dividends but provided the tournament with a heartening redemption arc. With an on-song MS Dhoni on strike, the left-armers shook off the ghosts of that five-sixes-in-a-row horror of last year by defending 16 runs in the final over, securing RCB's sixth consecutive win and a miraculous playoffs qualification. **Persisting with Rajat Patidar in the middle order, despite his indifferent start to the tournament, was also pivotal in turning RCB's fortunes around.**

This year's edition was the fastest-scoring one in the history of the tournament, registering eight of the ten highest team totals in the IPL, and yet all the playoffs went in favour of the team that bowled better.

With T20 batting expected to increasingly go into overdrive and the gaps in teams' power-hitting abilities shrinking, the razzmatazz of the shortest format may hinge more on the subtle art of bowling.



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